

JOUR 450: Investigative Reporting and Media Law

Term: Fall 2026 | Instructor: Prof. Bob Woodward (bwoodward@journalism.univ.edu)

Course Description & Overview:

Techniques of investigative accountability journalism, FOIA public records mining, database reporting, and First Amendment defenses.

COURSE ASSIGNMENTS & WEIGHT DISTRIBUTION

Assignment Description	Weight	Due Module	Deliverable Format
Public Records & FOIA Investigation	25%	Week 04	FOIA Audit & Dossier
Enterprise Feature Story	30%	Week 08	Longform News Article
Investigative Deep-Dive Project	35%	Week 11	Investigative Series Package
Newsroom Beat Reporting	10%	Continuous	Bi-Weekly Beat Memos

WEEKLY TERM SCHEDULE & READING REQUIREMENTS

Timeline	Technical Topic Focus	Assigned Readings & Docs
Week 01	Module 01: Ethics of Investigative Journalism	Kovach & Rosenstiel (Ch. 1–3)
Week 02	Module 02: FOIA Architecture & Public Records	FOIA Compliance Specs
Week 03	Module 03: Source Cultivation & Interviews	Houston (Ch. 4 & 5)
Week 04	Module 04: Campaign Finance & SEC 10-K Filings	SEC Filing Guidelines
Week 05	Module 05: Data Journalism & Spreadsheet Audits	Meyer (Ch. 2–4)
Week 06	Module 06: Defamation, Libel, and NYT v. Sullivan	Lewis (1991)
Week 07	Module 07: Confidentiality & Reporter Shield Laws	Branzburg v. Hayes
Week 08	Module 08: National Security & Espionage Act	Pentagon Papers Legal Dossier
Week 09	Module 09: Multi-Platform Investigative Packages	Pulitzer Case Studies
Week 10	Module 10: Fact-Checking & Editorial Verification	ProPublica Fact-Checking Guidelines
Week 11	Module 11: Final Project Showcase and Pitch	Investigative Series Review